

Let's talk... 100 years of service



The Anzac Centenary is an opportunity for Australians to recognise and honour the enduring spirit of all Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander service men and women who have served their country. To pay our respects to these oft-forgotten heroes, we have brought together a collection of stories spanning 100 years of service. Lest we forget.

The importance of recognition...



'At the going down of the sun, and in the morning, we will remember them.'

When the First World War broke out, Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples had few rights, poor living conditions, and were not allowed to enlist in the war effort. Despite this, many Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people wanted to serve in defence of Australia, and were willing to change their names, birth locations, heritage and nationality to do so.

Tim Muirhead, a passionate advocate for reconciliation in Western Australia, has written a moving reflection—in the [latest edition of Reconciliation News](#)—on the importance of remembering. “Remembering is essential in the work of recovery and reconciliation,” Tim says. “That’s true of war, and it’s true of the injustices that Aboriginal people have experienced over the last 100 years. So in remembering Aboriginal veterans, we should also remember what they and their families had to cope with on their return, and the human impact that this had on them.”

For Tim, the remembering should include empathy, but it should also include admiration. In his article he wrote: “As we remember those that fought and died shoulder to shoulder with their mates ... Let’s also remember their efforts, often supported by their white comrades, to be recognised as citizens on their return.”



Stories from the past...

When **Private Richard Martin** joined the Australian Imperial Force he declared on his papers that he was born in Dunedin, New Zealand, and that he had five years prior service in the Light Horse. He was not the only Aboriginal person to lie about his heritage in order to serve. Richard in fact was born on Stradbroke Island in Queensland. Richard served on Gallipoli in the 15th Battalion; he went on to serve in France and Belgium and was wounded in action three times. He was killed in action on March 28 1918. He is believed to be buried in the Military Cemetery Dernancourt Railway Line.

William Irwin, an Aboriginal man, joined up to defend his country in 1916, at the age of 37, serving in the 33rd Battalion. Having been wounded

three times in France and Belgium, William fought his last battle at Road Wood near Bouchavesnes in France. German machine gunners had pinned down William's battalion under fire, and had stopped the Allies advance. In an incredible show of heroism, William rushed the German machine gunners, likely saving numerous lives, but was mortally wounded. He would later receive posthumously the Distinguished Conduct Medal—one of only three known Indigenous soldiers to have been awarded the DCM.



Stories from the present...

Sergeant Anne Dufficy, a Tamwoy descendant from the Kodai (crocodile) Thupmul (Stingray) clan from Badu Island in the Torres Strait, joined the Australian Army when she was 18 years old. She is following in the footsteps of both her grandfather, Timothy Tamwoy, who served in the Torres Strait Light Infantry Battalion during the Second World



Stories from the present...

Chief Petty Officer Ray Rosendale, CSM, a Kuku Yalanji man of the Western Sunset Clan, whose traditional lands are situated northwest of Cairns in Far North Queensland, joined the Navy in 1991, and has served in various operational, peacekeeping and peacetime Navy roles. With his appointment to Navy Strategic Advisor on Indigenous Cultural

War, and her father, who was an Infantryman in the 2nd/4th Battalion, in the Royal Australian Regiment. Sergeant Dufficy has been deployed to the Middle East and Christmas Island, and has served in the 51st Battalion, the Far North Regiment in Cairns. Sergeant Dufficy believes the greatest benefit she receives from the Army is the sense of belonging, and she proudly continues the tradition of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Australians serving in the ADF.

Affairs, Chief Petty Officer Rosendale created history by becoming the first Indigenous serving member to hold a permanent position directly related to Indigenous affairs within the Australian Defence Force. Applauding the Navy's work towards diversity and inclusion, Chief Petty Officer Rosendale takes pride in the ADF's egalitarian values, which provided, and continue to provide, opportunities for Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples.

Take action...

The 100 years of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Anzac history has long been under-recognised, and we are grateful for this opportunity to pay our respects to all those who have served Australia. By creating a history in which everyone is recognised, we can create a more reconciled Australia. So, this year:

- Attend the [Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Commemorative Ceremony](#), held behind the Australian War Memorial, Canberra directly after the Dawn Service on Anzac Day.
- Explore the untold stories of Aboriginal soldiers by seeing the moving [Black Diggers production](#) touring nationally until May 2015.
- Watch NITV's specially commissioned 15-minute documentaries [ANZAC: Remembering Our Heroes](#).
- [Watch Air Force Group Captain Lisa Jackson Pulver](#) speak about the influence of her Aboriginal heritage in her current RAAF role, and the importance of creating a better future and having strong role models for all Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples.
- Contact the Australian War Memorial (gary.oakley@awm.gov.au or 02 6243 4532) if you have a story about an Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander serviceman.
- Read these stories and more in the [latest edition of Reconciliation News](#), dedicated to the service of Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander men and women.

Reconciliation Australia would like to thank the Australian War Memorial, the Queensland Theatre Company, Tim Muirhead and the Department of Defence for their assistance in the production of this factsheet.

Photo credits:

Banner photo: The Queensland Theatre Company's 'Black Diggers'. Image by Branco Gaica

Photo 1: Tim Muirhead delivering an address at the 'Commemorating Indigenous War Veteran' Ceremony, WA State War Memorial. Image by Tom Rovis-Hermann

Photo 2: Studio portrait of 1359 Private Richard Martin. Australian War Memorial: ID Number P00889.017

Photo 3: Warrant Officer Class One Ken Nelliman and Sergeant Annie Dufficy, Indigenous Recruiting Team, at the Australian Defence Force Career Expo, Townsville. Image courtesy of the Commonwealth of Australia, Department of Defence

Photo 4: Chief Petty Officer Ray Rosendale, CSM. Image courtesy of the Commonwealth of Australia, Department of Defence.

Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander peoples should be aware that this email may contain images or names of people who have since passed away.

Reconciliation Australia acknowledges the Traditional Owners of country throughout Australia and recognises their continuing connection to land, waters and community. We pay our respect to them and their cultures; and to elders both past and present.